

Limestone quarrying typically involves blasting the hillside apart using dynamite. In addition to destroying a part of the hills and causing pollution, blasting also weakens the rock and makes the area more prone to landslides.

Taking a stand

In 1987, Devi attended a seminar conducted by a local environmental group, which inspired her to take action. Now a frail fifty-five-year-old woman, she chose to take on forty-eight wealthy, powerful and politically connected mining companies. With the support of a volunteer group, she filed a Public Interest Litigation in the Himachal Pradesh High Court seeking a ban on mining in the area. When this failed to elicit a response, Devi began a hunger strike outside the court in protest. This helped focus attention on her case. Forced to look into the matter, the court finally ordered a stay on mining, later imposing a ban on blasting and directing the Ministry of Environment and Forests to undertake a study on the environmental impact of mining. The miners appealed to the Supreme Court against the decision in 1995, but they lost.